Rs 20,000 crore. Clearly, the ruling class knows the PWD's work has visible salience: roads, bridges and the like become key election issues.

"I'm aware of the challenges we face," says PWD minister Rakesh Singh, who seems intent on repairing the department's cracked image. The PWD had a quality cell that died a sudden death 14 years ago. Efforts are on to revive it. Training workshops are also being planned for all 1,644 engineers across the state's 10 divisions. "Engineers need to keep themselves abreast of emerging technologies," adds Singh.

NOT ENOUGH HANDS

Like most departments, the PWD faces a staff crunch. That 1,644 represents a shortfall of 40.8 per cent, against the total of 2,778 sanctioned posts, including deputations. Morale isn't flowing above danger mark either: promotions have been on pause since 2016, owing to a legal dispute over reservations. Given this disarray, a lot of the design work is now entrusted to consultancies. But outsourcing has become part of the problem, with increasing delays and misaligned objectives.

So, is there a design flaw in the Aishbagh flyover? PWD sources concede there are issues, but insist that the 'sharp turn' isn't one of them. In flyover design, they say, the turning radius is what's crucial. The code prescribes 15 metres. Here, it's a "safe" 20 metres.

Civil works entail big-ticket projects, and the financial stakes are very high, with deeply entrenched lobbies at work. For instance, two of the minister's ideas for an overhaul represented perhaps too sharp a turn for the system. One was procurement of bitumen, a key component in road construction, from Indian Oil Corporation, to ensure quality control. The second was peer review: chief engineers of all divisions were to go and inspect the works of other chief engineers, in random checks slated by a software. Both were heavily opposed, with engineers even threatening a strike. We need to see how that goes down the slope. ■

▶ GUJARAT

A RICH HARVEST OF RURAL SCAMS

NREGA and Nal Se Jal leak like faulty taps in tribal Gujarat as the corrupt milk flagship social schemes

By **Jumana Shah**

Takeaways

- **Inquiries have been ordered into a spate of rural scams in Gujarat**
- **Dahod, Bharuch, Vadodara, Mahisagar see identical methods**
- **Fictitious projects, backed by fake papers, skim off Rs 204 crore**
- **BJP has kept up a stoic silence, Congress demands an SIT probe**

FOUR SCAMS IN THREE months. The tribal soil of central-eastern Gujarat has of late been quite rich with embarrassment—and worse. Judge only by the expenditure domains that are seeing corruption inquiries: the execution of flagship social sector schemes, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA) in Dahod, Bharuch and Vadodara districts, and the Nal Se Jal scheme in Mahisagar district.

The misappropriation of funds, now being investigated, is said to have lightened the state exchequer by Rs 204 crore. The scams—Rs 71 crore in Dahod, Rs 7.3 crore in Bharuch and Rs 2.7 crore in Vadodara—reveal a near-identical pattern. Fictitious or incomplete infrastructure projects were passed off as complete for construction contractors to claim the money.

PHANTOM INFRA

Between January 2021 and December 31, 2024, infrastructure projects like roads, check walls and stone bunds had a phantom-like quality about them in Dahod—they existed only on paper. As befits the best fiction, a bit of fact was sometimes mixed in, as audits revealed. In Kuva village in Dahod, for instance, only 15,176 metres of the claimed 25,066 metres of roads were constructed; in Simamoi village, just 3,492 metres of 19,200 metres were built. Yet, full payments were disbursed.

The money was funnelled to some 32 unauthorised firms, including Shri Raj Construction Co. and Shri Raj Traders, which alone received Rs 30.04 crore and Rs 82 lakh, respectively, without entering the mandatory bidding processes. In Bharuch and Vadodara, construction agencies similarly defrauded the government through forged bills and manipulated tenders, with payments cleared for materials never supplied, or work left incomplete.

The scam in Dahod surfaced in January when local villagers complained to district authorities. An